

Section 0: Consent and Instructions

. This study explores how software developers experience emotional strain in their work and how this may be reflected in everyday development behaviors. Your participation is entirely voluntary and anonymous. You may stop the survey at any time without providing a reason. The study does not collect any personally identifiable information. There are no right or wrong answers. We kindly ask you to respond honestly, based on your recent work experience.

Estimated completion time: 12–15 minutes.

By continuing, I confirm that:

- I am at least 18 years old
- I understand that my participation is voluntary and anonymous
- I agree to take part in this study

☐ No

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. Your Prolific ID will only be used to verify completion and will not be linked to your personal identity. **(Only if you come from Prolific)**

Section 1: Pre-screening and Eligibility

. In the last 6 months, have you actively contributed code to a software project using version control (e.g., Git)?

- ☐ No
- ☐ Yes

. Which of the following best describes your current primary role?

Options:

- ☐ Software Engineer
- ☐ Software Developer / Programmer
- ☐ DevOps Engineer / SRE
- ☐ Data Engineer / Data Scientist / ML Engineer
- ☐ QA Engineer / Tester

- ☐ Technical Lead
- ☐ Other (please specify)

. In the last 4 weeks, how often have you committed code to a repository? Options:

- ☐ Never
- ☐ 1–2 times
- ☐ 3–5 times
- ☐ 6–10 times
- ☐ More than 10 times

. Attention check

To ensure data quality, please select "Agree" for this statement.

- ☐ 1 Strongly disagree
- ☐ 2 Disagree
- ☐ 3 Slightly disagree
- ☐ 4 Neutral
- ☐ 5 Slightly agree
- ☐ 6 Agree
- ☐ 7 Strongly agree

Section 2: Burnout

. Instruction: Please indicate how much you agree with the following statements, considering your work experience during the last month.

Scale 1–7 (Strongly disagree → Strongly agree)

. Emotional Exhaustion

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
I feel mentally exhausted by my software development work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel emotionally drained after working.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel worn out at the end of the workday.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

. Cynicism / Detachment

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
I feel more detached from my work than I used to.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel less emotionally involved in my project.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I distance myself from work-related interactions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

. Professional Inefficacy

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
I feel less effective in my development tasks.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Tasks that used to be easy now require much more effort.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I doubt the quality of my contributions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 3: Emotional Debt

. The following statements refer to emotional strain that accumulates over time and may persist across tasks and weeks.

Please indicate your agreement.

Scale 1–7 (Strongly disagree → Strongly agree)

. Emotional Debt

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
I carry unresolved emotional strain from my work over time.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotional stress from previous work continues to affect me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I keep working without addressing emotional difficulties related to work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
Accumulated frustration influences how I make work decisions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotional strain does not disappear even when tasks are completed.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel emotionally "in debt" due to prolonged work pressure.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 4: Emotional Smells

. Instruction: In the last 4 weeks, how often did the following occur?

Scale 1–5: (Never → Very often)

. Emotional Smells

	1 Never	2 Rarely	3 Sometimes	4 Often	5 Very often
I worked late at night or during weekends repeatedly. (Persistent Off-Hours Activity)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I made many small commits instead of fewer well-structured ones. (Workload Compression)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I committed code very frequently within short time periods. (High-Frequency Commit Pattern)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My commit messages expressed frustration or negativity. (Negative Commit Sentiment)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I wrote commit messages with little or no explanation (e.g., "fix", "again"). (Self-Referential Commits)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I avoided commenting, reviewing, or participating in discussions. (Communication Withdrawal)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

	1 Never	2 Rarely	3 Sometimes	4 Often	5 Very often
I worked on the same files or modules mostly alone. (Lone Contribution Pattern)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I reworked the same code multiple times in a short period. (Repeated Rework)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I reverted recent changes repeatedly. (Repeated Reverts)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I applied fixes that did not fully solve the problem. (Non-Resolving Fixes)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I used AI-generated code with minimal review or adaptation. (Uncritical AI Code Adoption)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

. Attention check

To ensure data quality, please select "Disagree" for this statement.

- ☐ 1 Strongly disagree
- ☐ 2 Disagree
- ☐ 3 Slightly disagree
- ☐ 4 Neutral
- ☐ 5 Slightly agree

- ☐ 6 Agree
- ☐ 7 Strongly agree

Section 5: Product Consequences

. Consequences

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
Emotional strain increases the likelihood of introducing bugs.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotional fatigue reduces code maintainability.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Burnout affects my ability to refactor effectively.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotional stress negatively impacts long-term software quality.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Under emotional strain, I tend to postpone quality-related improvements.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 6: Work Engagement

. Job Satisfaction

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
I feel energized by my work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel enthusiastic about my project.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I feel absorbed in my development tasks.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 7: Organizational Practices (Context)

. Instruction: Please indicate how much you agree with the following statements about your organization or team.

Scale 1–7 (Strongly disagree → Strongly agree)

. Organizational Practices

	1 Strongly disagree	2 Disagree	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree
My organization provides access to psychological support services.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Stress management or well-being training is available.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Workload is actively monitored and redistributed when needed.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Team-building activities are encouraged.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Retrospectives are used to discuss not only technical issues but also team well-being.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Tooling and automation reduce repetitive or stressful tasks.I emotionally “in debt” due to prolonged work pressure.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
These practices help reduce emotional strain over time.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

1							
Strongly disagree	2	3 Slightly disagree	4 Neutral	5 Slightly agree	6 Agree	7 Strongly agree	

These practices improve team well-being and collaboration.

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

. If you wish, briefly describe any practice that helped you manage stress or emotional strain at work.

Section 8: AI Usage

. How often do you use AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Copilot) for coding tasks?

- ☐ Never
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

. In your work context, AI tools are mainly:

- ☐ Not used
- ☐ Used informally by individuals
- ☐ Recommended by the team
- ☐ Officially supported by the organization

Section 9: Work Context and Demographics

. Age

- ☐ 18–24
- ☐ 25–34
- ☐ 35–44
- ☐ 45–54
- ☐ 55–65
- ☐ 65+

. Gender

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female
- ☐ Non-binary
- ☐ Prefer not to say

. Years of experience in software development

- ☐ Less than 1 year
- ☐ 1–3 years
- ☐ 4–6 years
- ☐ 7–10 years
- ☐ More than 10 years

. Team setup

- ☐ Fully co-located
- ☐ Hybrid
- ☐ Fully distributed (same country)
- ☐ Fully distributed (multiple countries)

. Number of time zones in your team

- ☐ One
- ☐ Two
- ☐ Three
- ☐ Four or more

. Which of the following best describes your current working arrangement?

- ☐ Fully on-site (office-based)
- ☐ Mostly on-site (1–2 days per week remote)
- ☐ Hybrid (3–4 days per week remote)
- ☐ Mostly remote (4–5 days per week remote)
- ☐ Fully remote

Section 10: Closing

. Did you find any question unclear or difficult to answer?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

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